and social and economic systems. In 1998, the Christian Liberation Movement's Oswaldo Payá founded the Varela Project, collecting signatures, according to Cuban law, for a referendum that proposed some fundamental changes to the Cuban political system. The Project called for a referendum on five issues: freedom of speech and association; freedom of the press; amnesty for political prisoners; the right of Cubans to form companies; and changes to Cuba's electoral laws.[33] The Varela Project explicitly distanced itself from other "dissident" and exile organizations, insisting that it operated within Cuban law and was committed to legal, nonviolent means of change.

In early 2003, increasing dissident activity – some of it linked to the U.S. Interests Section – coincided with a spate of armed attempts to hijack planes or boats to Florida. Several of these were successful, but Cuban officials intercepted an attempt to force a Havana Bay ferry to Miami, arresting the hijackers. Three hijackers were tried and sentenced to death, leading to a round of protest. Meanwhile, 75 members of dissident organizations were also arrested, and sentenced to up to 28 years in prison. An international outcry ensued.

About half of those arrested were associated with the Varela Project. They were accused, and soon convicted, of accepting funds and support from James Cason of the U.S. Interests Section. Cason, the Cuban Foreign Minister explained, had turned the Interests Section into a "headquarters of subversion against Cuba" and was using his diplomatic status as a cover for working to overthrow Cuba's government. Varela Project members were his witting, or unwitting, tools. By working as agents of a foreign government dedicated to the overthrow of Cuba's government, and by collaborating with the implementation of the Helms–Burton Act, they were violating Cuban law.[34] (Most of those who remained imprisoned were freed in July, 2010, in a deal brokered by the Spanish government and the Cuban Catholic Church.)

Disillusionment